Rohaniza Sumndad-Usman

Bai Rohaniza Sumndad-Usman (born c. 1984), widely known and beloved as "**Ate Honey**," is a Filipino peace advocate, community leader, and social entrepreneur whose life's work is rooted in a simple but powerful conviction: that peace is something you teach, not just something you hope for.

She is the **Founder and Chief Peace Mission Keeper** of the **Teach Peace Build Peace Movement (TPBPM) (https://tpbpm.org/)**, a non-profit organization dedicated to raising a generation of Filipino children and youth who don't just know the word "peace" but actually live it.

A Maranao on her father's side, Sumndad-Usman carries the blood of traditional Nobel custodians of peace and mediators in Mindanao. That heritage, combined with her own experience of war as a child and a lifetime spent bridging Muslim and Christian communities, makes her one of the most authentic voices for peacebuilding in the country today.

She has been called the **"Peace Princess of the Philippines"** and for good reason: from conflict zones in Mamasapano and Marawi to digital classrooms and interfaith forums around the world, Bai Rohaniza has spent decades turning the idea of peace into something children can hold in their hands.

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Early Life and Background

Bai Rohaniza Sumndad-Usman grew up at the intersection of two worlds that the Philippines often struggles to reconcile.

Her father comes from a Maranao Muslim family with a long lineage as traditional Nobel custodians of peace and mediators in Mindanao. That's not just a title. In Maranao society, these are the families entrusted with resolving conflict, maintaining harmony, and carrying the community's moral weight through generations of tension and change.

Her mother, on the other hand, is a Catholic-born musician from Bulacan who converted to Islam after marriage. Growing up in a household where the Quran and hymns, the azan and the sound of a piano, could all exist in the same space, Bai Rohaniza learned early that difference doesn't have to mean division.

That lesson came into sharper focus during her childhood years in **Riyadh, Saudi Arabia**, where her family had relocated. She was around seven years old when the **Gulf War** broke out. She remembers the sirens. She remembers the fear. And she remembers what it felt like to be a child with no control over the violence happening around her.

That experience didn't leave her. It shaped her. Everything she would go on to build professionally traces back to that little girl in Riyadh who decided, even then, that children shouldn't have to grow up like that.

Education

Sumndad-Usman completed her secondary education in Saudi Arabia before returning to the Philippines for college. She graduated from **Assumption College** in Manila, an institution known for its Catholic tradition and commitment to social responsibility.

For her senior thesis, she chose to write a comparative study between **Assumption (Christian) and Madrasa (Muslim) education**. Her conclusion was direct: prejudice, more often than not, is a product of ignorance. People fear what they don't understand.

That academic insight wasn't just theoretical for her. It confirmed what she'd already felt growing up in a home where faith was both diverse and unifying. And it gave her a framework she'd carry into every peacebuilding initiative she would later create.

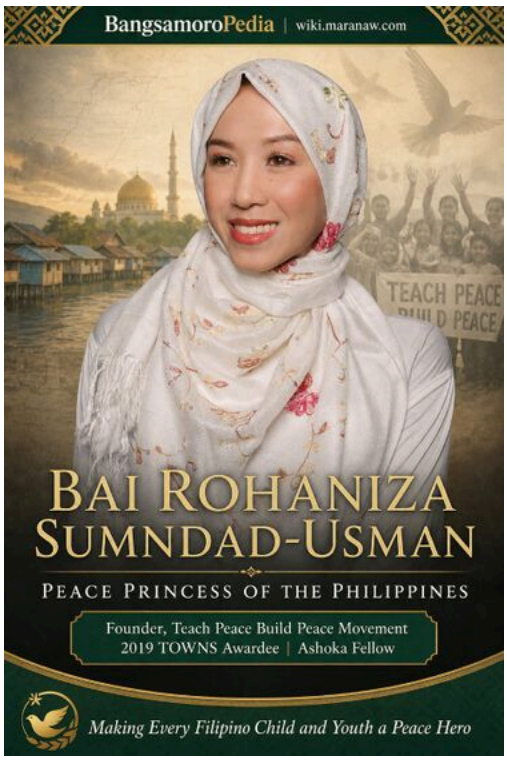
Career

Early Professional Work

Before founding her own movement, Sumndad-Usman cut her teeth in public service and civil society work. She started her career at the **Office of the Presidential Assistant for Youth Affairs**, where she got her first real exposure to policy-level thinking about young Filipinos.

She later moved into the international arena as the **Philippine Country Director for the Asia America Initiative (AAI)**, a US-based organization focused on people-to-people diplomacy and

Bai Rohaniza Sumndad-Usman



Born	c. 1984
Also Known As	"Ate Honey"; "Peace Princess"
Nationality	Filipino
Ethnicity	Maranao (paternal); Bulacan Tagalog (maternal)
Faith	Islam
Alma Mater	Assumption College
Occupation	Peace Advocate, Community Leader, Social Entrepreneur
Known For	Founding the Teach Peace Build Peace Movement (TPBPM)
Organization	Teach Peace Build Peace Movement (TPBPM)
Awards	Ashoka Fellow (2018); N-Peace Award (2013); TOWNS Awardee; Tatler Asia Gen.T (2020); DICID Award

post-conflict recovery in the Philippines. In that role, she established the **"Catalysts for Peace"** children's arm, which became an early proof-of-concept for her belief that peace education works best when it reaches children directly and in ways they actually enjoy.

Founding the Teach Peace Build Peace Movement

In **2013**, she took the leap and founded the **Teach Peace Build Peace Movement (TPBPM)**.

The organization's mission is as straightforward as it is ambitious: **"Make Every Filipino Child and Youth a Peace Hero."**

The TPBPM doesn't teach peace by lecturing at children. Instead, it uses what Bai Rohaniza calls the **Peace Heroes Formation Program**, a methodology built on music, arts, games, and sports to bring concepts like conflict resolution, empathy, and mindfulness to life in classrooms and communities.

The idea is that peace isn't abstract. It's a skill. And like any skill, it's best learned through practice.

Institutional Contributions and Key Initiatives

The Peaceable Classroom Toolkit

One of TPBPM's most practical contributions is the development of the **Peaceable Classroom Toolkit**, a structured resource designed to help teachers integrate peace education into their daily lessons. Rather than adding a separate "peace subject" to an already crowded curriculum, the toolkit gives educators the tools to weave peacebuilding into what they're already teaching.

Cyberpeace Campaign

Recognizing that today's children live as much online as they do offline, Sumndad-Usman partnered with **Google Philippines** on a **Cyberpeace Campaign** focused on digital citizenship and online kindness. The campaign acknowledged that the same skills needed to resolve conflicts in a classroom, listening, empathy, restraint, are the same skills needed to navigate social media without causing harm.

Conflict Zone Interventions

Perhaps the most emotionally significant dimension of TPBPM's work is its direct presence in conflict-affected areas. The movement has brought **psychosocial support and peace education** to communities in **Mamasapano** and **Marawi**, two places that carry deep wounds from violence and displacement. In these settings, the work isn't just educational. It's healing.

Legacy

Bai Rohaniza Sumndad-Usman has built something genuinely rare: a peacebuilding movement that operates at the level of the individual child while aspiring to reshape an entire nation's culture.

What makes her work sustainable is that it doesn't depend on political goodwill or government budgets. It's planted inside schools, inside communities, inside the habits of teachers and students who have internalized its principles. The TPBPM has reached children across the Philippines, including in some of the country's most fractured communities, and its methodology has gained international recognition as a model worth studying.

Beyond the programs and the awards, her legacy is also deeply personal. She is a Maranao woman who grew up between cultures, survived the psychological weight of wartime as a child, and chose to spend her adult life making sure other children don't carry that same weight. That's not a career. That's a calling.

Recognition

Bai Rohaniza's work has been recognized by both national and international bodies across her career:

- **Ashoka Fellow** (2018): One of the most prestigious honors in the social entrepreneurship world. She was inducted into Ashoka's global network, which recognizes individuals with innovative solutions to social problems.
- **N-Peace Award** (2013): Awarded by the **United Nations Development Programme (UNDP)**, which named her an "Emerging Peace Champion" in the region.
- **Doha International Center for Interfaith Dialogue (DICID) Award**: She was the first Filipino to be recognized by this Qatar-based institution for her contributions to interfaith tolerance and understanding.
- **Tatler Asia's Gen.T (https://www.tatlerasia.com/people/bai-rohaniza-sumndad-usman)** (2020): Listed among the "Leaders of Tomorrow" in the categories of philanthropy and public service.
- **TOWNS Awardee**: Honored by The Outstanding Women in the Nation's Service for her contributions to education and community development.

Challenges

Working for peace in the Philippines, particularly in Mindanao, has never been a clean or comfortable undertaking. Bai Rohaniza has had to carry her programs into communities still raw from conflict, navigate the skepticism of those who see peacebuilding as naive, and sustain a non-profit movement in a funding environment that doesn't always reward long-term, values-based work.

Her background as a Muslim woman working across religious and ethnic lines has also meant operating in spaces where she is simultaneously an insider and an outsider. That position carries its own kind of weight, but it's also, arguably, what makes her a credible bridge builder in both directions.

See Also

- Teach Peace Build Peace Movement
- Bangsamoro peace process
- Peace education in the Philippines
- Maranao people

External Links

- Teach Peace Build Peace Movement (TPBPM) (https://tpbpm.org/)
- Ashoka Fellow Profile (https://www.ashoka.org/en/fellow/bai-rohaniza-sumndad-usman)
- Tatler Asia Gen.T Profile (https://www.tatlerasia.com/people/bai-rohaniza-sumndad-usman)

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